Course Title: **Graphic Novels and World Politics**
Credits: CCC (1.5 credits)
Semester: Monsoon 2018 (Second half)
Course Instructor: Prof.Siddharth Mallavarapu
Department: International Relations and Governance Studies
School: Humanities and Social Sciences

Course Description

Graphic novels represent a distinct genre of telling stories. They provide a compelling lens to access layers of world politics. In the last few decades, there has been a surge in the creative production of graphic novels from around the world. Dealing with a wide range of themes, graphic novels unravel dimensions of conflict, reveal the life worlds of refugees, document genocides, celebrate lives of figures like Nelson Mandela and Frida Kahlo and tell stories from diverse cultural locations while constantly experimenting with narrative form. All of this make graphic novels a particularly interesting form to study, engage and experiment with and an indispensable ally in the task of interpreting world politics.

Course Aim

The aim of the course is to expose students to the richness of graphic novels as a distinct narrative form. Human stories especially as they pertain to different facets of world politics are of special interest in this context.

Learning Outcomes

There are two learning outcomes that are envisaged on completion of the course. These are listed below.

a. To access political worlds through graphic novels.
b. To develop an appreciation of the graphic novel as a distinct narrative form.

Contact Hours

Mondays and Wednesdays: 3.00 to 5.00 p.m. (and any other slot by appointment). My office is located on the second floor of the Central Library Block at E-363.

Weekly Plan

Week 1 (28th September, 2018)
Introductory class: Making Sense of Comics

Scott McCloud, 'The Vocabulary of Comics' in *Understanding Comics* (New York: Harper Perennial, 1994, pp.24-59

Week 2 (1st to 5th October, 2018)
'Taking Comics Seriously'

Suggested readings: Ada Goknur, 'Taking Comic Books Seriously', The Weekender: The Daily Californian, March 13, 2015.
http://www.dailycal.org/2015/03/13/taking-comic-books-seriously/

Arthur Asa Berger, 'Taking Comics Seriously' The Wilson Quarterly/Summer 1978, pp.95-101

Week 3 (8th to 12th October, 2018)
Introducing Joe Sacco

Suggested readings: Joshua Kavaloski, 'Discordant discourses: history and journalism in the novels of Joe Sacco', *Journal of Graphic Novels and Comics*, 2018.

Edward C. Holland & Carl T. Dahlman, 'Graphic Geopolitics: An Interview with Comics Artist Joe Sacco, *Geopolitics*, 2017; 22:1, 204-214.

Week 4 (22nd to 26th October, 2018)
Joe Sacco and his craft

Suggested Reading: Extracts from Joe Sacco, *Palestine* (1993).

Week 5 (29th October to 2nd November, 2018)
Introducing Art Spiegelman

Suggested Readings: Claudia Dreifus, 'Drawing is Always a Struggle': An Interview with Art Spiegelman, *The New York Review of Books* (2018).

Chris Mautner, 'It's only a Book': An Art Spiegelman Interview, *The Comics Journal*, November 17, 2011.

Week 6 (5th to 9th November, 2018)
Art Spiegelman and his craft

Suggested Reading: Extracts from Art Spiegelman, *The Complete Maus* (2003).

Week 7 (12th to 16th November)
Graphic Novels from India- I

Suggested reading: Durgabai Vyam, Subhash Vyam, Srividya Natarajan, S.Anand, *Bhimayana: Experiences of Untouchability* (Delhi: Navayana, 2011).

Week 8 (19-22 November)
Graphic Novels from India - II

Suggested Reading: Extracts from Sarbajit Sen, Debkumar Mitra, Sekhar Mukherjee and Pinaki De eds. *Longform: An Anthology of Graphic Narratives*, Vol.1 (Noida: Harper Collins, 2018).

Week 9 (26th November: Last Class)
Consolidation: 'Creating a Comics Canon'?

Suggested Reading: Paul Buhle, 'Creating a Comics Canon', *Los Angeles Review of Books*, December 23, 2017.

Evaluation Criteria

There will be a final examination at the end of the course (27th November, 2018) that tests your understanding of the content of what you have learnt through the entire CCC.

Research Ethics

Plagiarism is unacceptable in any form. I expect you to carefully peruse the 'Harvard Guide to Using Sources: What Constitutes Plagiarism?' <https://usingsources.fas.harvard.edu/avoiding-plagiarism>

Attendance Policy

Please refer to the Attendance Policy in your UG Handbook and online at <https://snulinks.snu.edu.in/snuPolicies/students/UG%20Handbook%202018%20V1.1%2014%20June%202018.pdf>